

The indicative mood

There are three main moods in English. Most verbs are used in the indicative mood, which indicates an actual condition, as opposed to an intended, expected, or believed condition. This mood is used to state facts.

This sentence states a fact—something that was the case at some point in the past—so it is in the indicative mood.

The boy **was** terrified.

The imperative mood

The imperative mood is used to give commands or make requests. Exclamations are often in the imperative mood; these always end with an exclamation point.

This command is also an exclamation.

This is a request.

Go away! Please **leave** me alone.

The subjunctive mood

The subjunctive mood is rarely used in English, and it can only be identified in the third person form or with the verb *be*. It is used after verbs and phrases that express an obligation or a desire, such as *demand*, *require*, *suggest*, or *it is essential that*, and it indicates that the obligation or desire may not be fulfilled.

▷ Third person

To form most subjunctive verbs, the final *s* is removed from the third person form.

He **demanded** that the zookeeper **remove** the snake.

The present subjunctive follows the verb phrase *demanded that*. It is used because the zookeeper might not remove the snake.

▷ Exception

The main exception is the verb *be*, which takes the form *be* for the present tense and *were* for the past tense.

The zookeeper **requested** that the boy **be** quiet.

The present subjunctive follows the verb phrase *requested that*. The zookeeper wants the boy to be quiet, but the boy might not be quiet.

GLOSSARY

Auxiliary verb A “helping” verb like *be* or *have* that links the main verb in a sentence to the subject.

Exclamation A sentence that expresses a strong emotion, such as surprise, or a raised voice, and ends with an exclamation point.

Modal auxiliary verb An auxiliary verb that is used with an action verb to express a command, an obligation, or a possibility.

Past participle The form of a verb that ends in -ed or -en. It is used with the auxiliary verb *be* to form the passive voice.



Identifying the subjunctive in conditional sentences

Conditional sentences are used to indicate that the action of a main clause (“going to the beach”) can only happen if a certain condition, contained in a subordinate clause, is fulfilled (“if the weather is hot”). Most conditional sentences start with *if* or *unless*. If the action being described is almost certain to happen, the indicative mood is used. If the action being described is hypothetical (impossible to predict), the past tense form of the subjunctive mood should be used.

Many conditional sentences start with *if*.

If the weather...

They will almost certainly go to the beach if the weather is hot, so the indicative mood is used.

If the weather **is** hot, we **will go** to the beach. ✓

If the weather **were** hot, we **would be** happier. ✓

The weather is not hot, so the belief that they would be happier is a hypothetical situation, which requires the subjunctive verb form *were*.

The modal auxiliary verb *would* usually appears in conditional sentences with the subjunctive.